

WHO CONTROLS BITCOIN?

A Deep Research Report on the World's Top 20 Biggest Bitcoin Holders

FILE 3 OF 3 · THE POWER

Category 5: Governments · Category 6: Private Whales

The final file covers the most dramatic Bitcoin holders on Earth — the nation-states that never chose to own Bitcoin but now hold billions in seized criminal proceeds, and the private whales whose early conviction and extraordinary wealth creation set the template for everything that followed.

RESEARCHED & AUTHORED BY

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CATEGORY 5

GOVERNMENTS

SOVEREIGN BITCOIN HOLDERS

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ENTITY #15 · SOVEREIGN GOVERNMENT · CATEGORY 5

United States Government

HOLDINGS	USD VALUE	HOW ACQUIRED	RESERVE STATUS
328,372 BTC	~\$26 Billion	100% Seizures	Strategic Reserve
Confirmed May 2026	At ~\$81,000/BTC	Zero purchased	Exec Order Mar 2025

BACKGROUND — THE ACCIDENTAL BITCOIN SUPERPOWER

The United States government is the world's largest sovereign holder of Bitcoin — and it never once chose to buy a single coin. Every Bitcoin in the US government's possession was seized from criminals: dark web drug dealers, hackers, fraudsters, ransomware operators, and money launderers. For over a decade, the standard procedure was straightforward: seize the Bitcoin, wait for court-ordered forfeiture, then auction it off through the US Marshals Service.

That policy ended on **March 6, 2025**, when President Donald Trump signed an executive order creating the **Strategic Bitcoin Reserve (SBR)**. The order directed all federal agencies to consolidate their seized Bitcoin holdings into a single reserve managed by the US Treasury Department, and prohibited any future sales of seized Bitcoin without explicit Congressional approval. As of May 2026, the US government holds approximately **328,372 BTC** — worth roughly \$26 billion at current prices — making it the most consequential sovereign Bitcoin position on Earth.

The story of how the US government accumulated 328,372 BTC is really the story of American law enforcement's extraordinary capability in blockchain forensics. The FBI, IRS Criminal Investigation, DEA, Secret Service, and Department of Justice have together built what is arguably the most sophisticated cryptocurrency tracing operation in the world. They can follow Bitcoin across hundreds of transactions, through mixing services, across blockchain bridges, and through exchanges — and they have used that capability to recover billions.

8 KEY GOVERNMENT FIGURES

Donald J. Trump

47th President of the United States — Signed the Strategic Bitcoin Reserve

Donald John Trump was born on June 14, 1946, in Queens, New York City, the fourth child of Fred Trump, a real estate developer, and Mary Anne MacLeod Trump. He attended Kew-Forest School in Forest Hills before being sent to the New York Military Academy at age 13 — a boarding school in Cornwall-on-Hudson that his father chose to instil discipline. He enrolled at Fordham University in 1964 before transferring to the Wharton School of Business at the University of Pennsylvania, graduating in 1968 with a bachelor's degree in economics. He joined his father's real estate firm, Elizabeth Trump and Son, upon graduation and eventually took over and renamed it The Trump Organization. Trump built a real estate empire in Manhattan, Atlantic City, and globally, including the iconic Trump Tower on Fifth Avenue, before pivoting to entertainment as host of NBC's The Apprentice (2004-2015). He ran for President in 2016 as a Republican, defeating Hillary Clinton in one of the most shocking electoral upsets in American history. He served as 45th President 2017-2021. After losing the 2020 election to Joe Biden and the subsequent January 6 Capitol riot, Trump faced two impeachments and multiple criminal indictments before staging the most remarkable political comeback in modern American history, winning the 2024 presidential election decisively. Trump's relationship with Bitcoin evolved dramatically. He once called it a 'scam.' By 2024, he was speaking at the Bitcoin 2024 conference in Nashville, pledging to make the US 'the crypto capital of the planet,' promising never to sell government Bitcoin, and committing to a Strategic Bitcoin Reserve. He signed that reserve into existence on March 6, 2025, making him the most pro-Bitcoin US president in history. He also pardoned Ross Ulbricht — founder of the Silk Road — in January 2025, a deeply symbolic act that resonated powerfully with the Bitcoin community.

Scott Bessent

Secretary of the Treasury

Scott Bessent was born in 1962 in Conway, South Carolina. He earned a BA from Yale University in 1984, where he was a student of the legendary investor and Yale endowment manager David Swensen. After Yale, Bessent went to work on Wall Street, eventually becoming a partner and the Chief Investment Officer at Soros Fund Management — the hedge fund of billionaire George Soros. He ran Soros's European office and later his global macro strategies. He founded his own macro hedge fund, Key Square Group, in 2015. Bessent was nominated as Treasury Secretary by Trump and confirmed by the Senate in January 2025. As Treasury Secretary, Bessent oversees the management of the Strategic Bitcoin Reserve — the world's most consequential government Bitcoin position. He has described Bitcoin as an important part of America's financial future and has been involved in developing the policy framework for how the reserve will be managed going forward.

David Sacks

White House AI and Crypto Czar

David Sacks was born in Cape Town, South Africa, and emigrated to the United States where he attended Stanford University, graduating with a BA in Economics in 1994. He was a member of the legendary 'PayPal Mafia' — the group of PayPal alumni who went on to found or fund some of Silicon Valley's most consequential companies. Sacks was PayPal's first COO and later founded Yammer (acquired by Microsoft for \$1.2 billion in 2012), Craft Ventures (a venture capital firm), and Glue (an enterprise AI platform). He was appointed White House AI and Crypto Czar by Trump in January 2025 — the first person ever to hold this specific role. Sacks is the primary day-to-day manager of US crypto policy within the White House, including the development of the Strategic Bitcoin Reserve framework. He revealed in early 2025 that the US had previously held approximately 400,000 BTC through cumulative civil and criminal forfeitures over the past decade before some were sold through Marshals Service auctions — coins that would now be worth approximately \$32 billion.

Paul Atkins

SEC Chairman (2025 onwards)

Paul Atkins served as an SEC Commissioner from 2002 to 2008 under Presidents Bush and Obama before founding Patomak Global Partners, a financial regulatory consulting firm. He replaced Gary Gensler as SEC Chairman in early 2025 — a transition that immediately and dramatically changed the SEC's relationship with the crypto industry. Where Gensler pursued an aggressive enforcement-first strategy, suing Coinbase, Ripple, Binance, and dozens of crypto companies, Atkins has pursued a rules-based approach: write clear regulations first, enforce them fairly second. Under his leadership, the SEC dropped or settled many of Gensler's lawsuits, issued clearer guidance on crypto asset classifications, and approved several new digital asset ETF products.

Cynthia Lummis

US Senator, Wyoming — The Bitcoin Senator

Cynthia Lummis was born in Cheyenne, Wyoming in 1954. She attended the University of Wyoming, graduating with a BS in Animal Science before earning her JD from the University of Wyoming College of Law in 1985. She served in the Wyoming state legislature from 1978 to 1994, as Wyoming State Treasurer from 1999 to 2007, and as Wyoming's sole US Representative from 2009 to 2013 before becoming a US Senator in 2021. Lummis is the most vocal and persistent Bitcoin advocate in the US Senate. She has held Bitcoin since 2013 and has been transparent about her personal holdings. Her landmark legislative proposal — the BITCOIN Act — would direct the US Treasury to purchase 1 million Bitcoin over five years, funded by revaluing the Federal Reserve's gold certificates at market prices rather than the statutory \$42.22/oz. While the BITCOIN Act has not passed as of mid-2026, it has advanced the national conversation about sovereign Bitcoin accumulation and given the crypto industry a credible congressional champion.

Kash Patel

FBI Director (2025 onwards)

Kashyap 'Kash' Patel was born in Garden City, New York, to Gujarati immigrant parents. He received his undergraduate degree from the University of Richmond and his law degree from Pace University School of Law. He was a public defender in Miami before joining the National Security Division of the Department of Justice in 2014. He served on the House Intelligence Committee under Congressman Devin Nunes and became a prominent figure in Trump's first term. Appointed FBI Director in early 2025, Patel oversees the agency that conducts the largest and most complex Bitcoin seizure operations in the world. The FBI's Cyber Division and its partnerships with IRS Criminal Investigation represent the operational sharp end of the US government's Bitcoin accumulation through law enforcement.

Bo Hines

Executive Director, Presidential Council of Advisers for Digital Assets

Bo Hines is a former football player who played wide receiver at Wake Forest University and briefly as a professional, and later ran for US Congress from North Carolina in 2022 (narrowly losing). He was appointed by Trump as Executive Director of the newly created Presidential Council of Advisers for Digital Assets — the body that advises the President on the Strategic Bitcoin Reserve and broader crypto policy. At a press briefing in March 2025, Hines outlined several 'budget-neutral' strategies being explored for expanding the reserve, including the gold certificate revaluation concept and surplus revenues from the Federal Reserve. He has become one of the most frequent White House spokespersons on Bitcoin reserve matters.

IRS Criminal Investigation (IRS-CI)

The Blockchain Forensics Unit That Cracked Bitcoin Crime

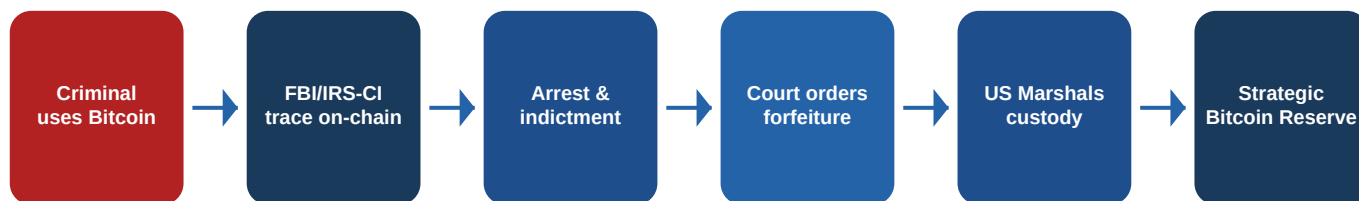
IRS Criminal Investigation is not an individual but an agency — and no single institution has done more to build the US government's Bitcoin holdings through law enforcement excellence. IRS-CI agents pioneered the use of blockchain analytics to trace stolen and laundered cryptocurrency, developing techniques that private firms like Chainalysis and Elliptic have since commercialised. Their most famous case was the Bitfinex hack recovery in 2022 — tracking 119,754 stolen Bitcoin through hundreds of transactions, mixing services, and obscure exchanges to the New York apartment of Ilya Lichtenstein and Heather Morgan. That \$3.6 billion recovery remains the largest financial seizure in US government history. IRS-CI also led the recovery of the James Zhong case (9,800 BTC), the Bitcoin Fog case, and numerous ransomware seizures.

COMPLETE SEIZURE HISTORY — HOW THE US BUILT ITS BITCOIN RESERVE

Every Bitcoin in the US government's possession was seized from criminals. Here is the complete record of the major cases that built the Strategic Bitcoin Reserve:

- **SEIZED** Oct 2013 · 144,000 BTC · Case: Silk Road — Ross Ulbricht — *FBI shuts down dark web marketplace. Ulbricht sentenced to two life terms in 2015.*
- **SEIZED** Nov 2020 · 69,370 BTC · Case: Silk Road — Individual X — *Mystery figure who stole BTC from Silk Road in 2012 surrenders coins to DOJ.*
- **SEIZED** Nov 2021 · 9,800 BTC · Case: James Zhong Case — *Georgia man who hacked Silk Road in 2012 and hid 9,800 BTC in a Cheetos tin under floorboards.*
- **SEIZED** Feb 2022 · 94,643 BTC · Case: Bitfinex Hack — Lichtenstein & Morgan — *Largest financial seizure in US history. IRS-CI traces stolen BTC to married couple in NYC.*
- **SEIZED** 2022–2023 · 12,267 + 2,818 BTC · Case: Additional Bitfinex forfeitures — *Related seizures from co-conspirators and intermediary accounts.*
- **SEIZED** 2024–2025 · 127,271 BTC · Case: Prince Group Criminal Organisation — *Largest single Bitcoin forfeiture in DOJ history. ~\$14 billion at time of seizure.*
- **SEIZED** Ongoing · ~12,000+ BTC · Case: Various ransomware, fraud, darknet cases — *Continuous stream of smaller seizures across multiple agencies.*
- ◆ **NOTE** Jan 2025 · Silk Road BTC — court approves sale of 69,370 BTC. DOJ moves ~\$2B to Coinbase Prime days before Trump inauguration.
- ◆ **NOTE** Jan 2025 · US Marshals Service reports possible hack of government digital asset accounts. \$60M+ possibly stolen from seizure wallets.
- ◆ **NOTE** Mar 6, 2025 · Trump signs executive order. All seized Bitcoin now held as Strategic Bitcoin Reserve. No more auctions.
- ◆ **NOTE** May 6, 2026 · David Witt discloses at Consensus Miami: US holds 328,372 BTC — confirmed government figure for first time.

THE SEIZURE-TO-RESERVE CYCLE — FLOW DIAGRAM



Before March 2025, Step 6 was 'Marshals Auction — Bitcoin sold to public.' Trump's executive order changed Step 6 permanently: hold, never sell.

THE STRATEGIC BITCOIN RESERVE — CHALLENGES AHEAD

Despite the executive order's drama, the Strategic Bitcoin Reserve faces significant unresolved challenges as of mid-2026. Congressional approval for the reserve architecture has not been secured. The reserve currently has no mechanism for active Bitcoin acquisition — it can only grow through new seizures, which are unpredictable. Senator Lummis's BITCOIN Act, which would authorise active purchases, has not passed. The custody architecture is still being consolidated — coins were previously stored in 'drawers of desks in various agencies' across multiple government departments, according to a White House official. The January 2025 Marshals Service hack highlighted the urgent need for centralised, professional custody. Until these issues are resolved, the world's largest government Bitcoin position remains more symbolic than fully operational.

MARKET IMPACT

The US Strategic Bitcoin Reserve is the single most geopolitically significant development in Bitcoin's history since Satoshi's disappearance. When the world's most powerful government formally declares Bitcoin a national reserve asset — placing it in the same strategic category as gold, oil, and foreign currency reserves — it sends an irreversible signal to every other sovereign government on Earth about Bitcoin's long-term legitimacy.

The 328,372 BTC held by the US government represents approximately 1.65% of total supply. Combined with the government's official 'no sell' policy, this removes a significant amount of Bitcoin from potential market supply. Every day the reserve grows through new seizures, another tranche of Bitcoin is removed from circulation — permanently.

ENTITY #16 · SOVEREIGN GOVERNMENT · CATEGORY 5

People's Republic of China

HOLDINGS	USD VALUE	HOW ACQUIRED	POLICY
~194,000 BTC	~\$15.7 Billion	PlusToken Seizure	BTC Banned
PlusToken seizure	At ~\$81,000/BTC	2019 Ponzi scheme bust	Contradictory position

BACKGROUND — THE CONTRADICTIONARY BITCOIN SUPERPOWER

China's relationship with Bitcoin is one of the most striking contradictions in global finance. The Chinese Communist Party has banned Bitcoin trading, banned Bitcoin mining, banned cryptocurrency exchanges, and repeatedly declared Bitcoin illegal for its 1.4 billion citizens. Yet the Chinese government itself sits on an estimated **194,000 BTC** — the second-largest government Bitcoin holding on Earth — worth approximately \$15.7 billion at current prices. Every single coin was seized from Chinese nationals who operated or invested in the PlusToken Ponzi scheme — the largest cryptocurrency fraud in history.

The PlusToken scheme was a massive multi-level marketing scam that operated across China, South Korea, and Southeast Asia between 2018 and 2019. It promised returns of 10-30% monthly on crypto deposits. At its peak, it had attracted approximately 3 million investors and collected an estimated **200,000 BTC**, 880,000 ETH, and billions in other assets. In June 2019, the scheme collapsed and six of its operators were arrested. Chinese authorities seized the assets. In February 2020, a Chinese court sentenced 15 PlusToken operators to prison terms of 2-11 years and formally transferred the seized assets to state ownership.

8 KEY GOVERNMENT FIGURES

Xi Jinping General Secretary of the Chinese Communist Party & President

Xi Jinping was born on June 15, 1953, in Beijing, the son of Xi Zhongxun, a revolutionary veteran and former Vice Premier. His childhood was marked by the turbulence of the Cultural Revolution — his father was purged and persecuted, and Xi was sent to work in rural Shaanxi Province at age 15 as part of Mao's reeducation campaign, spending seven years in a cave dwelling. He studied chemical engineering at Tsinghua University through a workers-peasants-soldiers programme and later earned a PhD in law from Tsinghua in 2002. Xi rose through provincial leadership roles before becoming General Secretary in 2012 and President in 2013. He has consolidated more personal power than any Chinese leader since Mao Zedong, abolishing presidential term limits in 2018. His government has been the most consistently hostile to Bitcoin of any major power — banning mining in 2021, shutting exchanges, and prosecuting thousands for crypto-related activities. The extraordinary irony is that his government simultaneously holds the world's second-largest government Bitcoin position — a fact that has never been officially acknowledged.

Li Qiang Premier of the State Council

Li Qiang has served as Premier of China since March 2023, managing the country's economic policy including financial regulation. He previously served as party secretary of Shanghai, where he oversaw China's financial capital during its cryptocurrency exchange shutdown operations in 2021. As Premier, his economic team manages the administrative aspects of China's seized asset portfolio, including the PlusToken Bitcoin holdings that reside in government-controlled accounts.

Yi Gang

Former Governor, People's Bank of China (2018–2023)

Yi Gang served as Governor of the People's Bank of China during the critical period when China's most aggressive anti-crypto policies were implemented. Under his leadership, PBOC issued multiple warnings about Bitcoin, banned financial institutions from handling crypto transactions, and ultimately supported the sweeping 2021 mining and trading bans. His successor Pan Gongsheng has continued the same hostile regulatory stance.

Pan Gongsheng

Governor, People's Bank of China (2023 onwards)

Pan Gongsheng became PBOC Governor in July 2023, taking over China's central bank during a period of economic challenge including a property market crisis and deflationary pressures. His policies have maintained China's hostile stance toward private cryptocurrency while aggressively promoting the Digital Yuan (e-CNY) as China's state-controlled alternative. The contrast between China's brutal suppression of Bitcoin for its citizens and its own holding of seized Bitcoin falls entirely within his institution's regulatory oversight.

Ministry of Public Security

The Seizure Authority

The Ministry of Public Security (MPS) — China's national police force — conducted the arrests and asset seizures in the PlusToken case. MPS officers arrested six primary PlusToken operators in Vanuatu in June 2019 in a joint operation, bringing them back to China for trial. The ministry's cybercrime divisions have become increasingly sophisticated in blockchain forensics, allowing Chinese law enforcement to trace and seize cryptocurrency from fraudsters and money launderers.

Supreme People's Court

Judicial Oversight of Asset Forfeitures

The Supreme People's Court provides judicial oversight of China's cryptocurrency forfeiture process. In a complex and somewhat opaque process, criminally seized crypto assets in China are transferred to local government finance departments, converted to RMB through state-controlled exchanges, or held in custody. China's legal framework for handling seized cryptocurrency is considerably less transparent than the US model, making it difficult to verify exact holdings.

National Development and Reform Commission (NDRC)

Mining Ban Authority

The NDRC issued the official guidance in 2021 that classified Bitcoin mining as an 'eliminated industry' — triggering the exodus of approximately 50% of global Bitcoin mining hash rate from China to Kazakhstan, the United States, Russia, and other jurisdictions. This single regulatory decision reshaped Bitcoin's global mining geography permanently, decentralising mining away from Chinese concentration.

Local Government Finance Departments

Physical Custodians

In China's legal system, criminally forfeited cryptocurrency is transferred to local government finance departments in the jurisdiction where the crime was prosecuted. This has created a fragmented custody picture — rather than a single central reserve like the US model, China's Bitcoin holdings are likely distributed across multiple provincial and municipal finance offices, in wallets controlled by local officials with varying levels of technical sophistication. The centralisation status of these holdings is unknown.

THE PLUSTOKEN STORY — THE BIGGEST CRYPTO FRAUD IN HISTORY

PlusToken was a smartphone application launched in 2018 that promised users monthly returns of 10-30% by supposedly using an AI-powered arbitrage trading system to profit from cryptocurrency price differences between exchanges. It spread virally through WeChat groups, Telegram channels, and in-person meetings across China, South Korea, Japan, and Southeast Asia, using a multi-level marketing structure that rewarded recruiters for bringing in new investors. It was, in reality, a pure Ponzi scheme with no real trading activity.

At its peak in 2019, PlusToken had attracted an estimated 3 million investors and had collected approximately 200,000 BTC, 880,000 ETH, 26 million LTC, and billions in other assets — making it the largest cryptocurrency fraud by value

ever discovered. The scheme collapsed in June 2019 when six operators were arrested. Chinese authorities eventually seized the assets and distributed them to state control. Fifteen operators received prison sentences ranging from 2 to 11 years in February 2020.

Blockchain analysts identified that large tranches of the PlusToken Bitcoin were being moved and apparently sold through OTC brokers between 2019 and 2021, contributing to significant downward price pressure during that period. The remaining estimated 194,000 BTC appear to have been transferred to government-controlled wallets and have not moved significantly since.

BITCOIN SEIZURE HISTORY

■ **SEIZED** Jun 2019 · ~200,000 BTC initial · Case: PlusToken Ponzi scheme collapse — *Six operators arrested in Vanuatu. Assets frozen.*

◆ **NOTE** 2019–2021 · Portions of PlusToken BTC moved through mixers and OTC desks. Estimated 6,000+ BTC sold, affecting market.

■ **SEIZED** Feb 2020 · Final forfeiture · Case: PlusToken — 15 convictions — *Court transfers remaining assets to state. Estimated ~194,000 BTC retained.*

◆ **NOTE** May 2021 · China bans Bitcoin mining. Massive hash rate exodus begins. China's own BTC holdings unaffected.

◆ **NOTE** Sep 2021 · China declares all cryptocurrency transactions illegal. Still holds ~194,000 BTC itself.

◆ **NOTE** May 2026 · ~194,000 BTC in government custody. Policy on these coins: officially undisclosed. No announced selling programme.

MARKET IMPACT

China's 194,000 BTC holding is the most dangerous wild card in Bitcoin markets. Unlike the US Strategic Reserve, which has a clear 'hold forever' policy, China has made no official statement about its Bitcoin holdings. If China decided to sell its entire position — which would require no public announcement and could be executed quickly through OTC channels — it would represent approximately 1% of total supply hitting the market, likely triggering a significant short-term price decline. The market monitors Chinese government wallet movements with considerable anxiety.

ENTITY #17 · SOVEREIGN GOVERNMENT · CATEGORY 5

United Kingdom Government

HOLDINGS	USD VALUE	PRIMARY AGENCY	POLICY
~61,000 BTC	~\$4.9 Billion	Metropolitan Police / NCA	Case by case
Law enforcement seizures	At ~\$81,000/BTC	& HMRC	No formal reserve

BACKGROUND

The United Kingdom holds approximately 61,000 BTC accumulated through a series of law enforcement seizures conducted by the Metropolitan Police Service, the National Crime Agency (NCA), and HM Revenue and Customs (HMRC). Unlike the United States, which has a formal Strategic Bitcoin Reserve with an explicit 'no sell' policy, the UK manages its seized cryptocurrency on a case-by-case basis under existing proceeds of crime legislation.

The most significant UK Bitcoin seizure was the July 2021 case involving Jian Wen — a Chinese national living in London who was convicted of money laundering in May 2024. She was found to have laundered Bitcoin on behalf of Yadi Zhang, the mastermind of a \$6 billion investment fraud in China. The Metropolitan Police seized approximately **61,245 BTC** linked to this case — the largest cryptocurrency seizure in UK history and one of the largest law enforcement Bitcoin seizures ever globally.

8 KEY FIGURES

Keir Starmer

Prime Minister

Sir Keir Starmer was born on September 2, 1962, in Southwark, London. He studied law at the University of Leeds and St Edmund Hall, Oxford, graduating with first-class honours. He practised as a human rights barrister for many years before being appointed Director of Public Prosecutions (DPP) and Head of the Crown Prosecution Service in 2008, a role in which he served until 2013, earning a knighthood. He was elected MP for Holborn and St Pancras in 2015 and became Labour Party leader in 2020, leading Labour to a landslide general election victory in July 2024. As Prime Minister, Starmer's government has maintained a cautious but constructive approach to crypto regulation, commissioning the Financial Conduct Authority (FCA) to develop a comprehensive regulatory framework for digital assets while allowing law enforcement to continue building its seized Bitcoin portfolio.

Rachel Reeves

Chancellor of the Exchequer

Rachel Reeves, born in 1979 in Lewisham, London, is an economist who studied PPE at New College, Oxford, and later worked at the Bank of England as an economist. She was elected MP for Leeds West in 2010 and became Chancellor of the Exchequer in July 2024 — the first woman ever to hold that office. As Chancellor, she oversees HM Treasury, which is responsible for managing seized criminal assets including the UK's Bitcoin holdings. Her treasury team is developing policy on how the UK's seized Bitcoin should be managed, sold, or held over the long term.

Nikhil Rathi

Chief Executive, Financial Conduct Authority (FCA)

Nikhil Rathi, born in 1979, is CEO of the Financial Conduct Authority — the UK's primary financial regulator. Under his leadership, the FCA has been building the regulatory framework for UK crypto markets. The FCA has been registering crypto asset firms since 2020 under anti-money-laundering rules and is developing a comprehensive crypto market regulation in line with EU MiCA legislation. The FCA's regulatory stance directly affects how UK seized Bitcoin assets are managed and ultimately disposed of.

Graeme Biggar

Director General, National Crime Agency (NCA)

Graeme Biggar leads the National Crime Agency — the UK's equivalent of the FBI — which has developed significant cryptocurrency investigation capability. The NCA works on major cross-border crypto crime cases including money laundering, ransomware, and darknet markets. It has seized hundreds of millions in cryptocurrency across multiple investigations and works closely with US authorities on shared cases. The NCA's Cyber and Financial Intelligence directorate is on the front line of building UK crypto forensic expertise.

Metropolitan Police Service — Economic Crime Command

Primary London Seizure Authority

The Metropolitan Police's Economic Crime Command conducted the landmark Jian Wen seizure — the largest cryptocurrency confiscation in UK history. The command includes specialist financial investigators who work on complex money laundering cases involving cryptocurrency. The Jian Wen case involved sophisticated work tracing Bitcoin across multiple wallets and jurisdictions, demonstrating that UK law enforcement has developed comparable blockchain forensics capabilities to their US counterparts.

HM Revenue and Customs (HMRC)

Tax Authority & Seizure Body

HMRC has its own cryptocurrency seizure powers under tax law and proceeds of crime legislation, independent of police seizures. HMRC has seized cryptocurrency from tax evaders and money launderers in multiple cases, adding to the UK government's overall Bitcoin holdings. HMRC has also been developing clear tax guidance on cryptocurrency transactions — a critical step in building the regulatory infrastructure for legitimate crypto markets.

Crown Prosecution Service (CPS)

Prosecution & Forfeiture Authority

The Crown Prosecution Service prosecutes the criminal cases that result in Bitcoin forfeitures, working with police and the NCA to secure court orders transferring seized assets to government control. The CPS's asset recovery team has developed expertise in navigating the complex legal questions around cryptocurrency ownership and forfeiture that arise in UK court proceedings.

Jian Wen (Subject)

The Central Figure in UK's Largest Bitcoin Seizure

Jian Wen was a Chinese national living in Hendon, North London, who worked at a Chinese restaurant before suddenly beginning to live an extraordinarily lavish lifestyle — renting a £17,000-per-month mansion in London, attempting to buy £23 million properties, acquiring luxury goods, and travelling in private jets. Metropolitan Police investigators discovered she was laundering Bitcoin on behalf of Yadi Zhang — a Chinese fraudster who had orchestrated a \$6 billion investment fraud that victimised thousands of Chinese investors. Zhang had converted the fraud proceeds into Bitcoin and moved them to London. Wen was convicted of money laundering in May 2024 and sentenced to six years and eight months in prison. The case resulted in the seizure of 61,245 BTC.

UK BITCOIN SEIZURE HISTORY

■ **SEIZED** 2018–2020 · Various smaller amounts · Case: Multiple drug trafficking & fraud cases — *Early UK crypto seizures through police and NCA operations.*

■ **SEIZED** Jul 2021 · ~61,245 BTC · Case: Jian Wen / Yadi Zhang — money laundering — *Metropolitan Police seize £3.2B+ in Bitcoin. UK's largest ever crypto seizure.*

◆ **NOTE** May 2024 · Jian Wen convicted. Six years eight months imprisonment. Forfeiture order confirmed.

◆ **NOTE** 2024–2026 · ~61,000 BTC in government custody. Managed under POCA (Proceeds of Crime Act 2002). No formal holding policy announced.

MARKET IMPACT

The UK's 61,000 BTC position is significant but its future is uncertain. Unlike the US, there is no explicit 'strategic reserve' declaration, meaning the coins could be sold by court order or government decision at any time. The UK's approach to crypto regulation is evolving — and how it manages this enormous seized asset will likely serve as a

template for other European jurisdictions grappling with the same question.

ENTITY #18 · SOVEREIGN GOVERNMENT · CATEGORY 5

Republic of El Salvador

HOLDINGS	USD VALUE	TOTAL SPENT	UNREALISED GAIN
7,643 BTC	~\$619 Million	~\$622 Million	~\$400 Million
As of May 2026	At ~\$81,000/BTC	Cost basis	At peak BTC prices

BACKGROUND — THE MOST DRAMATIC BITCOIN STORY IN SOVEREIGN HISTORY

El Salvador is a small Central American nation of approximately 6.5 million people with a GDP of around \$34 billion — barely 0.03% of the US economy. Yet it has produced the most dramatic and discussed Bitcoin policy experiment in sovereign history, driven entirely by the vision and conviction of one man: **President Nayib Bukele**.

On **September 7, 2021**, El Salvador became the first country in the world to make Bitcoin legal tender — meaning all businesses in the country were legally required to accept it as payment. The announcement sent shockwaves through the global financial community. The IMF warned against it. Rating agencies downgraded El Salvador's debt. International economists predicted catastrophe. Bukele ignored them all and kept buying Bitcoin — publicly, enthusiastically, and relentlessly.

The story took a significant twist in early 2025 when El Salvador, facing a \$1.4 billion IMF loan negotiation, agreed to remove Bitcoin's mandatory legal tender status and halt the expansion of public-sector Bitcoin holdings as conditions of the deal. Bitcoin acceptance became voluntary rather than mandatory. However, Bukele continued buying Bitcoin anyway — his government added approximately 1,090 BTC in a single week during the 2025 market downturn and has continued its daily one-Bitcoin-per-day accumulation programme.

8 KEY FIGURES

Nayib Armando Bukele Ortiz

President of El Salvador — The Bitcoin President

Nayib Bukele was born on July 24, 1981, in San Salvador, El Salvador, into a prominent and wealthy family of Palestinian-Salvadoran origin. His father, Armando Bukele, was a successful businessman and Imam of the Islamic Association of El Salvador — a fascinatingly multicultural origin for Central America's most unconventional leader. His mother, Olga Marina Ortez, is of Salvadoran descent. Nayib attended the Universidad Centroamericana (UCA) in San Salvador, studying law, though he did not complete his degree — leaving to manage the family advertising business, which grew under his direction into one of El Salvador's most successful marketing firms. His political career began in 2012 when he was elected mayor of Nuevo Cuscatlán — a small municipality west of San Salvador. His administration became known for transparency, effectiveness, and social media engagement. He was elected mayor of San Salvador itself in 2015, making him the most visible young politician in the country. In 2019, running against the two parties that had dominated Salvadoran politics for decades, Bukele won the presidential election with 53% of the vote on his first round — an extraordinary margin. He was 37 years old. His governing style is unconventional: he appears in military fatigues during National Assembly confrontations, governs heavily through social media, and has concentrated significant power in the executive. Critics describe him as authoritarian; supporters point to El Salvador's dramatic reduction in gang violence and improving economy. At the Bitcoin 2021 conference in Miami, Bukele appeared via video to announce the Bitcoin legal tender law — the room erupted. He has since announced Bitcoin purchases on X at all hours, bought the dip publicly multiple times, and framed Bitcoin as a tool of economic sovereignty for developing nations unable to control monetary policy. He survived the IMF pressure in 2025 with his personal conviction intact, continuing daily purchases despite the policy concessions. As of May 2026, El Salvador's total acquisition cost is approximately \$622 million on 7,643 BTC — with significant unrealised gains at current prices.

Stacy Herbert

Director, Bitcoin Office of El Salvador

Stacy Herbert is an American journalist, podcaster, and Bitcoin advocate who co-hosts the Keiser Report with her husband Max Keiser. She relocated to El Salvador after the Bitcoin legal tender announcement and was appointed Director of the Bitcoin Office — the government body responsible for Bitcoin adoption policy, the Chivo wallet, and Bitcoin-related economic development. She has been one of the most effective communicators of El Salvador's Bitcoin story to an international audience, framing it as a sovereignty play rather than a speculation.

Max Keiser

Senior Bitcoin Advisor to President Bukele

Max Keiser is an American broadcaster, filmmaker, and Bitcoin maximalist who has been one of the most vocal Bitcoin advocates since at least 2011 — making him one of the earliest mainstream media Bitcoin voices. He was appointed Senior Bitcoin Advisor to President Bukele and helped design El Salvador's Bitcoin strategy, including the daily one-Bitcoin purchase programme. He co-hosts the Keiser Report with Stacy Herbert.

Alejandro Zelaya

Minister of Finance

Alejandro Zelaya has served as El Salvador's Finance Minister throughout Bukele's presidency, managing the complex challenge of balancing the IMF loan negotiations and the country's sovereign Bitcoin purchases. He has been the formal government spokesperson on El Salvador's fiscal policy and the Bitcoin treasury's financial performance, defending the strategy in international forums.

Douglas Rodriguez

President, Banco Central de Reserva (Central Bank)

Douglas Rodriguez heads El Salvador's central bank, which manages the country's monetary policy and foreign reserves — now including Bitcoin. He has navigated the extraordinary challenge of integrating Bitcoin into El Salvador's reserve framework while maintaining relationships with the IMF and international financial institutions that remain deeply sceptical of the experiment.

Milena Mayorga

Former Ambassador to the United States

Milena Mayorga served as El Salvador's Ambassador to Washington DC during the critical period when El Salvador was negotiating US reaction to the Bitcoin legal tender law. She was instrumental in managing the diplomatic relationship with the US government and Treasury Department regarding El Salvador's Bitcoin policy, given that any significant US sanctions or financial pressure could have been existential for the small country's economy.

Claudia Ortiz

Opposition Legislator — Chief Critic of Bitcoin Policy

Claudia Ortiz is a National Assembly legislator from the Viva party and one of the most persistent critics of El Salvador's Bitcoin experiment. Her opposition provides important democratic context: not all Salvadorans support the policy. Surveys showed that a majority of the population was sceptical or opposed to the Bitcoin legal tender law, particularly small business owners who struggled with the technical requirements. Her arguments against — volatility risk, IMF pressure, limited actual adoption — reflect genuine concerns that even some Bitcoin supporters acknowledge as valid for a developing economy.

Bukele's Tech Team — Chivo Wallet Developers

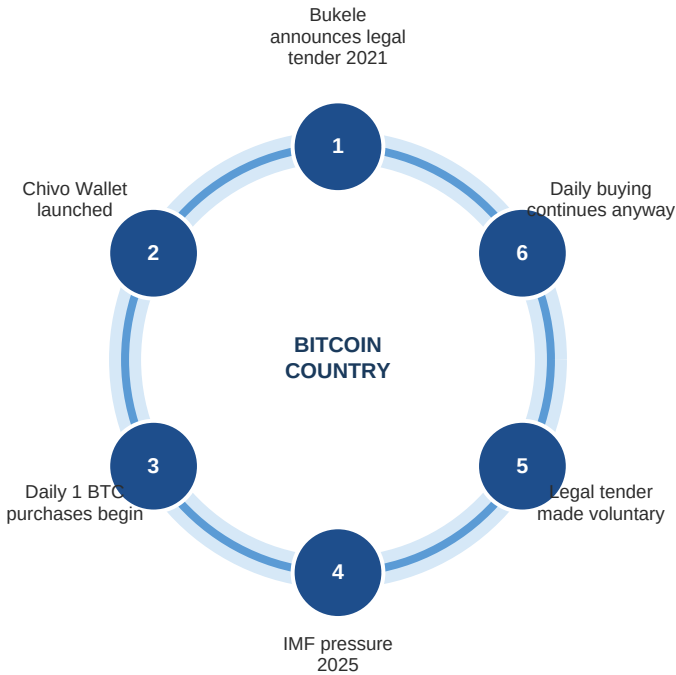
Bitcoin Adoption Infrastructure

The technical team behind the Chivo wallet — El Salvador's government-run Bitcoin wallet that every Salvadoran citizen was given \$30 in Bitcoin to download — represents the operational execution of the Bitcoin legal tender experiment. The Chivo app was developed under intense time pressure and launched with significant technical problems, including reports of identity fraud and app crashes. Despite these challenges, it onboarded millions of Salvadorans to Bitcoin in a matter of weeks — a genuine mass adoption event with no parallel anywhere in the world.

COMPLETE BITCOIN PURCHASE HISTORY — ONE COIN A DAY

- ▲ **BUY** Sep 6, 2021 · 200 BTC · \$~\$50,000/BTC · Total: \$10M — *First official government purchase. Day before Bitcoin became legal tender.*
- ▲ **BUY** Sep 7, 2021 · 21 BTC · \$~\$50,000/BTC · Total: \$1.05M — *Bitcoin Day. Legal tender law takes effect. Symbolic 21 BTC buy.*
- ▲ **BUY** Sep 2021 – Dec 2021 · ~1,120 BTC · \$\$43,000–\$68,000/BTC · Total: ~\$60M — *Daily 1 BTC purchases begin. Treasury accumulation programme established.*
- ▲ **BUY** May 9, 2022 · 500 BTC · \$\$30,744/BTC · Total: \$15.4M — *Bukele publicly buys the dip during market crash. Tweets 'El Salvador just bought 500 Bitcoin.'*
- ▲ **BUY** Jun 2022 · 80 BTC · \$\$19,000/BTC · Total: \$1.52M — *Continues buying during deepest bear market. Tweets 'We are buying the dip.'*
- ▲ **BUY** 2022–2024 · ~1,100 BTC (approx) · \$Varied bear market/BTC · Total: ~\$35M — *Consistent daily purchases. Holdings cross 5,000 BTC by early 2024.*
- ▲ **BUY** Sep 7, 2025 · 21 BTC · \$~\$95,000/BTC · Total: \$2M — *Fourth anniversary of Bitcoin Day. Symbolic 21 BTC purchase.*
- ▲ **BUY** Nov 2025 · ~1,090 BTC · \$\$75,000–\$85,000/BTC · Total: ~\$85M — *Aggressive bottom-buying during 2025 market crash. Tweets 'Hooah!'*
- ▲ **BUY** Jan 29, 2026 · 1 BTC · \$\$84,000/BTC · Total: \$84,000 — *Daily purchase continues. Holdings reach 7,547 BTC.*
- ◆ **NOTE** May 2026 · 7,643 BTC total. Total cost ~\$622M. Significant unrealised gain at peak BTC prices.

EL SALVADOR'S BITCOIN JOURNEY — CIRCLE DIAGRAM



El Salvador's Bitcoin journey completed a full cycle: radical adoption, international pressure, partial policy retreat — but unwavering personal conviction at the top.

MARKET IMPACT

El Salvador's significance is symbolic and diplomatic rather than mathematical. Its 7,643 BTC holding is a tiny fraction of total supply. But its decision to make Bitcoin legal tender was the first time any sovereign nation gave Bitcoin the same status as a national currency — an act of legitimisation that no amount of institutional ETF launches or corporate treasury announcements could replicate. It demonstrated that Bitcoin could be adopted at the nation-state level, setting a template for every developing nation struggling with currency debasement, remittance costs, and financial exclusion.

CATEGORY 6

PRIVATE WHALES

THE EARLY BELIEVERS

19 · Tether · 20 · Winklevoss Twins

ENTITY #19 · PRIVATE COMPANY · CATEGORY 6

Tether Holdings Limited

HOLDINGS	USD VALUE	USDT SUPPLY	2025 PROFIT
~100,521 BTC	~\$8.1 Billion	\$184 Billion	\$10.9 Billion
As of Q4 2025	At ~\$81,000/BTC	World's #1 stablecoin	Paid in dividends

COMPANY BACKGROUND

Tether is the issuer of USDT — the world's most widely used stablecoin, with over \$184 billion in circulation as of mid-2026 — and has quietly become one of the largest corporate Bitcoin holders on Earth. Founded in 2014 as Realcoin by Brock Pierce, Reeve Collins, and Craig Sellars before being renamed and taken over by the iFinex group (which also owns Bitfinex), Tether operates one of the most profitable businesses in financial history from a structure of remarkable opacity.

Tether's business model is straightforward but extraordinarily lucrative: it issues USDT stablecoins — each supposedly backed 1-for-1 by real assets — and invests the reserve backing in US Treasury bonds and other instruments. With \$184 billion in USDT in circulation backed primarily by US Treasuries yielding approximately 5%, Tether generates approximately \$9-10 billion in annual interest income before expenses. This makes it one of the most profitable companies in the world by profit margin — generating billions from a relatively small operational team.

At the 2025 Bitcoin Conference in Las Vegas, CEO Paolo Ardoino announced that Tether holds more than **100,000 Bitcoin** as a company asset — alongside more than 50 tons of gold stored in Switzerland. Tether allocates approximately **15% of its net profits** to Bitcoin purchases, a policy that has been in place since 2023 and has resulted in quarterly purchases of thousands of BTC. In Q4 2025 alone, Tether purchased 8,888 BTC, moving them from Bitfinex to its reserve wallet in a single transaction.

8 KEY PEOPLE — FULL BIOGRAPHIES

Giancarlo Devasini

Co-Founder & Chief Financial Officer — The World's Most Secretive Billionaire

Giancarlo Devasini was born in 1964 in Turin, in the Piedmont region of northern Italy, into a middle-class family. Turin is Italy's industrial heart — home of Fiat, Juventus, and a deeply practical engineering culture that shaped his character. He attended the University of Milan, graduating with a degree in medicine in 1990. He practised as a cosmetic surgeon and plastic surgeon briefly — perhaps two years or less — before making one of the most consequential career pivots in modern business history. He abandoned medicine entirely to enter the information technology business in the early 1990s, founding several companies specialising in the distribution of computer components and electronics across Europe. The path was turbulent: in 1995, Microsoft accused his company of selling pirated software, resulting in a fine of approximately one million Italian lire. Several of his businesses subsequently went bankrupt, including Acmetek, a Belgian chip distribution company. Yet Devasini persisted, building operational and financial expertise through repeated cycles of failure and rebuilding. Around 2012, he discovered Bitcoin and saw something profound: a new financial system that could exist outside the banking infrastructure he had spent years fighting to access. He met Raphael Nicolle and joined Bitfinex as co-founder and CFO in late 2012. In 2014, working with Nicolle, JL van der Velde, Brock Pierce, and Paolo Ardoino, he co-launched Tether — flying personally to banks in the Bahamas, Switzerland, and Hong Kong to open accounts for the then-controversial stablecoin project. Between 2017 and 2023, he ran Tether's billion-dollar operation from an office above a sports bar in Lugano, Switzerland — a characteristic modesty that belies his extraordinary wealth. As of April 2026, Forbes ranks Devasini as the 23rd-richest person in the world with an estimated net worth of \$89.3 billion — making him the wealthiest person in Italy and one of the most consequential private figures in global finance. He holds approximately a 45-47% stake in Tether. He almost never appears in public, gives no interviews, and has deleted his social media accounts. His wealth has been built in near-complete silence.

Paolo Ardoino

Chief Executive Officer of Tether & CTO of Bitfinex

Paolo Ardoino was born on October 22, 1984, in Cisano sul Neva — a tiny village of fewer than 1,000 people in the Ligurian Apennines of northern Italy. His upbringing in a remote mountain village gave him both a self-reliance and an outsider's perspective on the established order of things. He studied computer science at the University of Genoa, graduating in 2008. He began his career as a researcher on a military project focused on high-availability, self-recovering networks and cryptography — giving him the technical foundation in distributed systems that would prove essential at Tether. He taught himself finance and economics after university, taking a job at a hedge fund in 2011 building trading systems, then moved to London in 2013 to run his own startup, Fincluster, which built trading software for hedge funds. In London in 2014, he met Giancarlo Devasini, who was operating Bitfinex from the same city. Devasini recognised Ardoino's rare combination of deep cryptographic knowledge, distributed systems expertise, and trading technology experience, and hired him as a Senior Software Developer. In 2017, Ardoino made an almost incomprehensible 40,000 code commits on GitHub — averaging over 100 per day — demonstrating a work intensity that became legendary in the crypto developer community. He became CTO of Bitfinex in 2015 and added the CTO role at Tether in December 2017. He was appointed CEO of Tether in December 2023. Under his public-facing leadership, Tether has grown from a \$1 billion to a \$184 billion stablecoin. Forbes reported in 2024 that Ardoino holds approximately 20% of Tether — a stake worth potentially \$100 billion if the company's \$500 billion valuation estimates are accurate. He was a guest at the White House for the signing of the GENIUS Act stablecoin legislation — a remarkable moment of mainstream legitimisation for a company that spent years fighting existential regulatory challenges. He is confirmed as a speaker at Bitcoin 2026 in Las Vegas.

JL van der Velde

Chief Executive Officer of Bitfinex

Jan Ludovicus van der Velde was born in the Netherlands but has spent over 40 years in Asia after relocating to Taiwan in 1985 to study Chinese language and technology at National Taiwan Normal University. His decades of experience in Asian markets proved critical to Bitfinex and Tether's early growth in China, Hong Kong, Japan, and Southeast Asia — regions that historically drove the largest global volumes of Bitcoin trading. He became co-founder and CEO of Bitfinex in 2013 and simultaneously CEO of Tether for many years. Forbes estimated his net worth at approximately \$9.5 billion in 2025. He is famously private — present but invisible.

Stuart Hoegner

Former General Counsel (2018–2024)

Stuart Hoegner graduated from Yale University with a BA in Physics in 1994 before pursuing law. His physics background made him particularly effective in understanding the technical dimensions of the crypto assets he defended. He was the primary legal architect of Tether and Bitfinex's defence during the New York Attorney General's investigation (2019–2021), which resulted in an \$18.5 million settlement and new reporting requirements. His work navigating years of regulatory scrutiny while keeping Tether operational was arguably the most consequential legal representation in crypto history. He retired in 2024 and reportedly holds approximately 13% of Tether.

Brock Pierce

Original Co-Founder of Tether

Brock Pierce is perhaps the most colourful figure in Tether's origin story. A former child actor (The Mighty Ducks, D2), Pierce became a teenage video game entrepreneur before pivoting to crypto. He co-founded Tether in 2014 as Realcoin. He departed from Tether's operations early but remained a figure in the broader crypto space, running for US President in 2020 and investing heavily in Puerto Rico as a crypto community base. His departure left Devasini and van der Velde as the operational architects of what Tether became.

Reeve Collins

Original Co-Founder of Tether

Reeve Collins co-founded Tether in 2014 alongside Brock Pierce and Craig Sellars. He served as CEO of the company initially before departing in 2015. He went on to found other crypto projects. Like Pierce, his departure in the early stages left the company's long-term direction in the hands of the iFinex team.

Craig Sellars

Original Co-Founder & Technical Architect

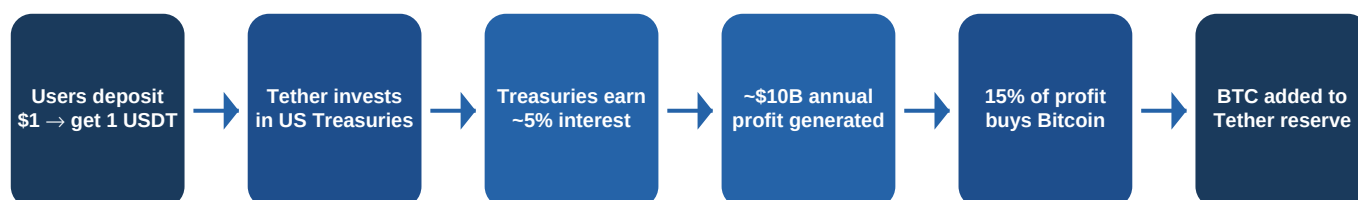
Craig Sellars was the primary technical architect of the original Tether protocol, building the Omni Layer on top of Bitcoin that allowed USDT to exist as a token. His work created the technical foundation of the world's most important stablecoin. He departed Tether in 2015 and went on to found other projects in the crypto space.

Matthew Sigel

VanEck Head of Digital Assets Research — Key External Analyst

Matthew Sigel of VanEck, an external figure but critical to understanding Tether's Bitcoin holdings, has been one of the most detailed public analysts of Tether's reserve attestations and Bitcoin accumulation. His research team at VanEck has tracked Tether's quarterly 15% profit-to-Bitcoin purchase policy and estimated the forward accumulation pace. At Tether's current profit levels, the 15% policy generates approximately \$1.6 billion in annual Bitcoin purchases.

HOW TETHER GENERATES BILLIONS AND BUYS BITCOIN



Tether's stablecoin business generates billions in Treasury interest. 15% of net profit is systematically converted to Bitcoin — approximately \$1.6 billion in annual BTC purchases at current profit levels.

BITCOIN ACQUISITION HISTORY

◆ **NOTE** 2014–2022 · Tether focused on stablecoin operations. Bitcoin held operationally through Bitfinex relationship but no formal treasury programme.

◆ **NOTE** Nov 2022 · FTX collapse triggers crypto contagion. Tether survives, demonstrating reserve strength. Strategic decision made to diversify reserves into Bitcoin.

▲ **BUY** 2023 · Initial purchases · \$~\$28,000–\$43,000/BTC · Total: Billions in net profit available — *15% profit-to-BTC policy formally adopted. Systematic quarterly purchases begin.*

▲ **BUY** Q4 2024 · ~8,000 BTC · \$~\$65,000–\$95,000/BTC · Total: ~\$640M — *Consistent quarterly accumulation.*

▲ **BUY** Q4 2025 · 8,888.89 BTC · \$~\$90,000/BTC · Total: ~\$800M — *Ardoio announces: Tether moved 8,888 BTC from Bitfinex to reserve in single transaction.*

◆ **NOTE** Bitcoin 2025 Conference (Las Vegas) · Ardoio announces: Tether holds 100,000+ BTC. Also holds 50+ tons of gold in Switzerland.

◆ **NOTE** May 2026 · ~100,521 BTC in treasury. 15% profit policy continues. ~\$1.6B annual BTC purchases at current profit pace.

MARKET IMPACT

Tether's systematic Bitcoin purchasing programme — funded by the interest earned on the world's largest stablecoin reserve — represents one of the most structurally important and underappreciated Bitcoin demand flows in the market. Every dollar of USDT in circulation generates approximately \$0.05 in annual interest income for Tether, and 15% of that flows into Bitcoin. As USDT's supply grows — which it has done every year since inception — so does Tether's annual Bitcoin buying budget. This is Bitcoin demand that compounds with the growth of the entire stablecoin ecosystem.

ENTITY #20 · INDIVIDUAL WHALES · CATEGORY 6

Cameron & Tyler Winklevoss

EST. HOLDINGS	USD VALUE	FIRST BUY	EXCHANGE
~70,000 BTC	~\$5.7 Billion	Late 2012	Gemini (IPO Sep 2025)
Combined estimate	At ~\$81,000/BTC	~\$8–\$13/BTC	Nasdaq listed

BACKGROUND — FROM FACEBOOK LAWSUIT TO BITCOIN BILLIONS

Cameron and Tyler Winklevoss are identical twins who have lived one of the most extraordinary personal finance narratives in modern history: from being wronged in a Harvard dormitory in 2003, to Olympic rowers in Beijing in 2008, to Bitcoin billionaires by 2017, to running a publicly listed crypto exchange with a \$21 million political donation to a Trump-allied PAC in 2025. Their story is the story of Bitcoin's institutionalisation, told through the lives of two men who saw it coming before almost anyone else.

Cameron Howard Winklevoss and Tyler Howard Winklevoss were born on August 21, 1981, in Southampton, New York, and raised in Greenwich, Connecticut. Their father, Howard Winklevoss Jr., was an academic who taught pension actuarial science at the Wharton School of Business at the University of Pennsylvania and later founded a consulting firm applying those skills to corporate pensions. Growing up in Greenwich — one of the wealthiest communities in the United States — with a father steeped in financial mathematics gave the twins an early and deep comfort with complex financial concepts.

8 KEY PEOPLE — FULL BIOGRAPHIES

Tyler Howard Winklevoss

Co-CEO of Gemini & Co-Founder — The Strategist

Tyler Winklevoss attended Harvard University where he studied economics, graduating in 2004. His physical stature — 6 feet 5 inches — made him a natural rower, and he and Cameron rowed at Harvard's varsity level, reaching elite international competition. At Harvard in 2002, Tyler and Cameron developed a social networking concept called HarvardConnection (later ConnectU), designed to connect Harvard students. They hired fellow student Mark Zuckerberg to help build it in late 2003. Zuckerberg agreed, delayed working on their project for months, and in February 2004 launched his own social network — Facebook. The twins sued, arguing intellectual property theft. The case wound through the courts for years before settling in 2008 for approximately \$65 million in cash and Facebook stock. Tyler earned an MBA from Oxford University's Said Business School in 2010, gaining formal business education alongside his ongoing athletic career. At the 2008 Beijing Olympics, Tyler and Cameron were members of the US men's rowing eight — competing on the world's biggest athletic stage. They finished sixth. In 2013, Tyler filed paperwork to launch what would have been the world's first Bitcoin ETF — the Winklevoss Bitcoin Trust — under the ticker COIN on Nasdaq. The SEC rejected it in 2017 and again in 2018, citing market manipulation concerns. A decade before BlackRock succeeded, the Winklevoss twins tried. Tyler donated \$1 million in Bitcoin to Trump's 2024 campaign and \$21 million in Bitcoin to a Trump-aligned PAC in August 2025, making the twins among the largest individual crypto political donors in history. His net worth is estimated at \$2.5 billion as of April 2026.

Cameron Howard Winklevoss

President of Gemini & Co-Founder — The Communicator

Cameron Winklevoss attended Harvard alongside Tyler, also studying economics and graduating in 2004. He is the more publicly outspoken twin — more willing to make bold public statements, engage with media, and articulate the Bitcoin thesis in stark, memorable terms. In April 2013, Cameron told the New York Times: 'We have elected to put our money and faith in a mathematical framework that is free of politics and human error.' At a time when most mainstream commentators were calling Bitcoin a scam, that statement required real conviction and courage. Cameron earned an MBA from Oxford's Said Business School alongside Tyler in 2010. He has served as President of Gemini since its founding. He is the author of several public essays on Bitcoin, financial freedom, and the future of money. His net worth mirrors Tyler's at approximately \$2.5 billion as of April 2026. He was cast as himself in a cameo in HBO's Silicon Valley, embracing the cultural celebrity that came with being among the most famous Bitcoin holders in the world. In 2025, Cameron and Tyler purchased Bedford FC — a lower-league English football club — continuing their pattern of eclectic, conviction-driven investments.

Noah Perlman

Chief Executive Officer of Gemini

Noah Perlman is a former federal prosecutor who spent years at the Southern District of New York heading the Organised Crime and Gangs unit before transitioning to the private sector. He joined Gemini as Chief Compliance Officer before being elevated to CEO, a move that mirrored Binance's simultaneous decision to hire Perlman for the same role — the two companies were competing for the same compliance talent. As CEO, Perlman leads Gemini's day-to-day operations, freeing the Winklevoss twins to focus on strategy and advocacy.

Marshall Beard

President & Chief Strategy Officer

Marshall Beard serves as President and CSO of Gemini, overseeing strategic development including product expansion, international growth, and partnerships. Under Beard's strategic direction, Gemini has pursued expansion into futures trading, derivatives, and prediction markets, seeking to differentiate from larger competitors through regulatory credibility and product breadth.

Mike Breu

Chief Operating Officer

Mike Breu manages Gemini's operational infrastructure as COO, overseeing the systems that process Bitcoin trading, custody, and settlement for Gemini's customers. His role includes managing the technical custody of the estimated 70,000 BTC held by the twins personally, as Gemini is their primary custody and trading platform.

Howard Winklevoss Jr.

Father & Original Financial Mentor

Howard Winklevoss Jr. is the twins' father and an indirect but important figure in their story. His career as an actuarial science professor at Wharton and founder of a pension consulting firm gave Cameron and Tyler their earliest exposure to financial mathematics and the concept of long-term asset allocation. The discipline required to hold Bitcoin through multiple 80%+ drawdowns without selling — which the twins demonstrated consistently — likely owes something to a father who spent his career calculating long-term returns.

Nifty Gateway (now Gemini subsidiary)

NFT Platform

Nifty Gateway was an NFT marketplace acquired by Gemini in 2019 that became one of the most prominent NFT platforms during the 2021 NFT boom. Operated by the Winklevoss empire, it added significant revenue and brand recognition during the peak of the NFT market before the subsequent collapse in values. Its performance represents the diversification of the Winklevoss portfolio beyond Bitcoin into broader digital asset markets.

Winklevoss Capital Management

Venture Capital Arm

Winklevoss Capital Management is the twins' venture capital firm, which has invested in dozens of early-stage crypto and fintech companies. Their portfolio includes investments in companies across blockchain infrastructure, DeFi, and crypto security. The firm represents their ongoing bet on the broader digital asset ecosystem beyond their personal Bitcoin holdings and Gemini.

THE FACEBOOK STORY — THE ORIGIN OF THEIR BITCOIN FORTUNE

In the autumn of 2003, Cameron and Tyler Winklevoss were Harvard juniors with an idea for a social network exclusively for Harvard students. They called it HarvardConnection. They needed a programmer. A mutual friend connected them with a second-year student named Mark Zuckerberg, then known on campus mostly for a website called Facemash that had gotten him in trouble with the administration for scraping student photos. The twins hired Zuckerberg to build their site and paid him in equity. Zuckerberg agreed, communicated with them for weeks, then spent the following months working on something else — his own social network, TheFacebook, which launched in February 2004.

The twins sued. The case became one of Silicon Valley's most famous legal battles — dramatised in the 2010 film *The Social Network*, in which they were portrayed by Armie Hammer. The settlement in 2008 of approximately \$65 million in cash and Facebook stock was, at the time, a significant personal victory. But the true financial consequence came later, when those Facebook shares appreciated enormously, giving the twins a much larger capital base to invest. In late 2012, when they invested a significant portion of that capital into Bitcoin at approximately \$8-13 per coin, they made the most consequential personal investment decision in crypto history.

BITCOIN ACQUISITION HISTORY

▲ **BUY** Late 2012 · ~120,000 BTC initially · \$8–13/BTC · Total: ~\$11M total — *Facebook settlement money deployed. First major institutional Bitcoin bet by individuals.*

▲ **BUY** Early 2013 · Accumulation continues · \$~\$30–100/BTC · Total: Additional millions — *By April 2013, twins reportedly own ~1% of all Bitcoin in existence.*

◆ **NOTE** Apr 2013 · New York Times profile reveals twins' Bitcoin position. First mainstream media attention on individual Bitcoin whales.

◆ **NOTE** Jul 2013 · First-ever Bitcoin ETF filing with SEC (Winklevoss Bitcoin Trust, ticker COIN). Years ahead of competitors.

▼ **SELL** 2014 · Some BTC sold · \$~\$400–600/BTC · Total: Partial — *Funds used to launch Gemini exchange and operating costs.*

◆ **NOTE** Mar 2017 · SEC rejects Winklevoss Bitcoin Trust ETF. Market drops 17%. Twins vow to reapply.

◆ **NOTE** Jul 2018 · SEC rejects Winklevoss ETF again. Twins call the decision 'deeply flawed.'

◆ **NOTE** 2018–2021 · ~70,000 BTC held (estimate). Holdings stable through crypto winter and 2021 bull market.

◆ **NOTE** Sep 12, 2025 · Gemini IPO on Nasdaq. Twins go public for the first time.

▲ **BUY** Aug 2025 · 21M in BTC donated · \$~\$85,000/BTC · Total: \$21M — *Donated \$21M in Bitcoin to Trump-aligned PAC. Political conviction bet.*

◆ **NOTE** May 2026 · ~70,000 BTC estimated. Combined net worth ~\$5 billion. Gemini stock volatile post-IPO.

THE GEMINI IPO — SEPTEMBER 2025

On September 12, 2025, Gemini Trust Company went public on Nasdaq — one of the most anticipated crypto exchange IPOs since Coinbase's 2021 listing. The stock opened at \$45.89 before a tumultuous period that saw it fall dramatically. By early 2026, Gemini had reported a loss of \$159.5 million in its first public earnings report and cut 25% of its workforce as Bitcoin prices declined below \$70,000. The public market debut exposed Gemini to the same quarterly scrutiny that Coinbase had navigated — a significant transition for a company that had operated privately for over a decade.

MARKET IMPACT

The Winklevoss twins were, alongside Hal Finney, among the very first people outside the core developer community to treat Bitcoin as a serious, long-term asset worth significant personal capital. Their \$11 million investment in 2012-2013 at \$8-13 per coin was not a tech bet from people who didn't understand risk — it was a deliberate, conviction-driven allocation from two men who had just received a significant legal settlement and chose to put it into something almost no-one else was willing to touch. That conviction, demonstrated publicly and repeatedly, helped legitimate Bitcoin as an asset class for other high-net-worth individuals and eventually institutional investors who needed to see credible, sophisticated people making the same bet.

Their decade-long campaign to create a Bitcoin ETF — filing with the SEC in 2013, being rejected twice, watching BlackRock succeed in 2024 with essentially the same product — is one of the most poignant regulatory stories in finance. They pioneered a path they did not get to walk. But they walked it anyway, and the entire industry benefited.

FINAL CONCLUSION — WHAT ALL 20 HOLDERS MEAN FOR BITCOIN'S FUTURE

Across three files and twenty entities, a single overarching truth has emerged: Bitcoin's ownership structure in 2026 looks nothing like what its critics predicted, and everything like what its earliest believers hoped. The asset that was once dismissed as a toy for anarchists and criminals is now held by the world's largest asset manager, the most powerful government on Earth, and some of the most sophisticated financial minds of the modern era.

THE SIX CONCLUSIONS

1. CONCENTRATION IS A FEATURE, NOT A BUG

The top 20 holders analysed in this report collectively control over 6.5 million BTC — more than 30% of circulating supply. Critics call this dangerous concentration. Bitcoin advocates point out that gold ownership is far more concentrated, and that Bitcoin's concentration is transparently visible on a public blockchain in a way that gold's is not. More importantly, the concentration is becoming more diverse over time — spreading from early miners like Satoshi to exchanges, ETF issuers, corporate treasuries, governments, and retail holders globally.

2. GOVERNMENTS HAVE CROSSED THE RUBICON

The US Strategic Bitcoin Reserve represents a point of no return. Once the world's most powerful government formally declares a digital asset a national reserve — placing it alongside gold and foreign currencies — it becomes almost politically impossible for any future administration to reverse that without enormous credibility cost. El Salvador showed it could be done at sovereign scale. The US has shown it can be done at superpower scale. The question now is which other nations follow.

3. INSTITUTIONAL NORMALISATION IS PERMANENT

BlackRock's iShares Bitcoin Trust, Fidelity's FBTC, and the entire ETF ecosystem have permanently changed Bitcoin's institutional accessibility. These products cannot be uninvented. The \$80+ billion flowing through regulated ETF products gives pension funds, endowments, family offices, and individual retirement accounts access to Bitcoin through the same familiar brokerage interfaces they use for stocks and bonds. Adoption will only grow from here.

4. THE CORPORATE TREASURY REVOLUTION IS GLOBAL

What Michael Saylor started with \$250 million of MicroStrategy's cash in August 2020 has become a global corporate template. From Metaplanet in Tokyo to Strive in America to dozens of companies across Europe, Asia, and Latin America, the concept of holding Bitcoin on a corporate balance sheet has been normalised. The total corporate Bitcoin treasury market will likely exceed 2 million BTC within the next five years.

5. SATOSHI'S SHADOW DEFINES BITCOIN'S UNIQUE NATURE

No other asset class has a foundational story like Satoshi's: an anonymous creator who built something worth \$1.6 trillion, gave it to the world without charging for it, and then disappeared without taking a single dollar in profit. The 1.096 million BTC sitting dormant in Satoshi's wallets is the most powerful proof of Bitcoin's scarcity. Those coins are almost certainly gone forever — permanently reducing effective supply and making every other Bitcoin fractionally more precious.

6. THE NEXT FRONTIER IS SOVEREIGN COMPETITION

The most consequential development that has not yet fully played out is the potential for sovereign Bitcoin competition. If multiple nations begin competing to accumulate Bitcoin as a reserve asset — the way they once competed for gold — the resulting demand could be unlike anything the market has experienced. Senator Lummis's BITCOIN Act targets 1 million BTC for US purchase. If even a fraction of that ambition becomes reality across multiple sovereign actors,

Bitcoin's market dynamics will be transformed permanently.

END OF REPORT — FILE 3 OF 3

WHO CONTROLS BITCOIN?

File 1: The Origins · File 2: The Institutions · File 3: The Power

RESEARCHED & AUTHORED BY

NASIR BELLO (NBZ)

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Data sourced from: Arkham Intelligence · BitcoinTreasuries.net · Phemex · CoinCodex · Crypto.news · TheStreet Crypto · CoinDesk · Seoul Economic Daily · Blockworks · CCN · Benzinga · ChainCatcher · 99Bitcoins · Gate.com · Bitget Academy · Wikipedia · Forbes · Bloomberg · SEC EDGAR · Webopedia · Margex · Bitcoin Foundation · FXStreet · Yahoo Finance